

# FEMALE REPRODUCTIVE SYSTEM

THE FEMALE REPRODUCTIVE ORGANS RELEASE AN EGG AT REGULAR INTERVALS AND, IF IT IS FERTILIZED, PROTECT AND NOURISH THE EMBRYO AND FETUS.

## REPRODUCTIVE TRACT

The female reproductive glands (ovaries) lie within the abdomen. From puberty, they mature and release the female sex cells (gametes), known as egg cells or ova. This release occurs roughly once a month as part of the menstrual cycle (see p.283). The ripe egg travels along the fallopian tube to the uterus, the muscular sac in which, if fertilized, it develops into an embryo and then a fetus. Unfertilized eggs, and the uterine lining, are shed via the vagina. The ovaries also make the female sex hormone oestrogen.

## REPRODUCTIVE ORGANS

A cross-section through the female lower abdomen reveals the reproductive structures and organs. The ovaries sit against the abdominal wall. The fallopian tubes arch from them, opening into the muscular, thick-walled womb (uterus).



## ENDOMETRIUM

This electron micrograph shows the thick, folded, glandular endometrium (the lining of the uterus). The tissue shown is very rich in blood and ready to receive a fertilized egg.

**Rectum**  
Last section of  
large intestine

